You are ISTP
The Weapons Specialist!

As the ISTP Weapons Specialist, you do the absolute best you can at whatever you love, mastering your chosen specialty with a rugged, hands-on pragmatism.

There are numerous stereotypes and misconceptions about personality typing, but here we ll get to the root of it all: Cognition, the underlying thoughts and desires that make you who you are in your own individual way. You think the way you do for a reason. Your secret desires, interests, and fears make sense. Learning to understand how you think, why, and what you can do with it, naturally helps everything in life go more smoothly.
Cognitive typing is not a listing of simplistic limits or divisive caricatures. It s a set of tools, an open-ended guide to help you better understand everything that s already been going on inside you. This equips you to derive ever greater benefit, insight, and enjoyment out of being the incredibly complex and unique person you really are.

So, what does it really mean to be a cognitive ISTP?

You ve probably run into the letters ISTP before, maybe online or in books you ve read. Unfortunately, the way most sources define those letters is often a little shaky, focusing on behaviors instead of cognition. But behaviors change throughout a person s life, and two people might do the same behaviors for very different reasons. This leads to a difficulty in really nailing down who is and isn t ISTP, causing subjective arguments on the matter all over the internet. Worse, it leads to simplified misconceptions about what ISTP actually means. Getting back to the roots of cognition, your underlying thoughts and reasons why you do what you do, allows us to cut past all the simplifications and subjectivity.
Perhaps when you opened up this document and saw ISTP,

you immediately remembered unpleasant stereotypes that certainly don t apply to you. ISTPs are often portrayed as overly physical, reclusive, cold, condescending and even stupid, so you may have been tempted to think you couldn t possibly be ISTP. Well good, because those sorts of oversimplifications are simply untrue. They re stereotypes that have nothing at all to do with cognition, coming from shaky definitions of the letters that end up contradicting themselves and falling apart under the rigors of experience. Human thought is far more complex than that!

Being a cognitive ISTP does not place any limits whatsoever on your abilities, talents, career aptitude, behaviors, or attitudes. You can decide who you want to be. As you come to understand the way you already cognate, you ll naturally end up getting out of your own way, striding forward as the person you ve always been rather than sabotaging yourself by trying to hide who you really want to be.

These letters are merely a representation of the way you naturally approach the world. In every thought, every experience, and every interaction, we each make unconscious choices about what we re going to focus on most. These unwitting choices display what matters to us the most. Being an ISTP means that deep down, what matters most to you is expertly doing the best you can at whatever you love doing, in order to get the most use out of every situation. Your mind constantly chooses what to focus on first, based on this desire that reflects the core of everything it means to be you. This leaves all behaviors, attitudes, and abilities open to you, yet you will always end up approaching them in a way that reflects your deepest desire. All the letters and all their effects are simply results of what your mind naturally prioritizes in life, based on what you want most. Now let s get into defining those letters, so you can know what you re working with, get past all the simplified limitations, and just be you!

I Introvert

Being a cognitive Introvert has nothing to do with how social you may or may not be. It simply means that you naturally turn inward in order to process thoughts, decide on actions, and make judgments about the world and people. You tend to consider possibilities and ideas in the quiet laboratory of your own head before testing them out on the world around you. While cognitive Extraverts naturally observe, considering the opinions and actions of others and forming thoughts from the behaviors of their surroundings, Introverts usually form their own ideas and plans first before seeing how they

line up with the real world outside.

Social introversion, by contrast, is a behavioral habit that can change depending on a person s situation or mood. Cognition is the natural framework of thought beneath all one s changing habits and behaviors, the inner self that motivates all actions and attitudes of every kind. So don t worry if you don t consider yourself a social introvert; that s an entirely different matter from cognitive Introversion. Most sources in books and online deal with behavioral habits like social introversion or extraversion, but those behaviors are not cognition. Behaviors are about what you do, which can change dramatically in varying situations, but cognition is about how you think, beneath any and all behaviors.

There are times to be socially introverted and times to be socially extraverted, and any healthy person of any type will learn to develop both. Being overly socially introverted can in fact be a coping mechanism, a way to keep others at arm s length in order to avoid having one s weaknesses or insecurities brought into the light. Likewise, being overly socially extraverted can also be a coping technique, a way to try to escape or distract oneself from personal doubts or pain. Either behavior can be enjoyed healthily or clung to unhealthily, and all people, of all types, can be equally healthy or unhealthy in their social habits.

Yet cognitive Introverts, regardless of their social habits, approach all situations by looking inside themselves first in order to form thoughts. Everyone processes information inside their own heads, and everyone also observes outward, but cognitive Introverts consider thoughts first before anything else. They review their own understanding and experiences before going forward, preferring to have their thoughts and actions fully formed before releasing them into the world. Introverts constantly turn inward to process information and prepare output, so that their outward actions and words can be the best they can make them. They may be very social, or not, but in either case they are always mentally looking inward.

Being so focused inward, Introverts have a natural ability to decisively make choices without input from other people. This gives them a self-motivated drive, largely independent of the beliefs or actions of others. They must be careful, however, to take into account the views and desires of other people, which can often be quite surprising! The ideas or beliefs that worked so well in the laboratory of an Introvert s head might be totally thrown out the window in practice,

due to the unexpected actions of others.

This means that Introverts must guard against moral absolutism, an attitude that views differing opinions as simply wrong or foolish. All types can be morally absolutist or relativist, but Introverts can find it harder to fully understand the motives and views of others. The same objective facts can be viewed very differently by people coming from differing backgrounds or attitudes, and Introverts need to remember that their own internal laboratories always represent only one point of view. They can of course learn to better observe and consider the views of others, but their introspection means that it comes a little less naturally to them.

All this introspection can sometimes cause Introverts to appear aloof or detached, even if they re very social. When this introspective aloofness is not appreciated by others, Introverts can be induced to adopt social introversion as a result.

Yet cognitive Introverts possess a unique ability to be powerfully socially extraverted as well, since their inward focus allows them to adapt deliberately to their present companions or situation. Paying in-the-moment attention to their own words and actions, they can be cheerful or subdued, spontaneous or careful, putting others at ease and drawing energy from all around them, in whatever way the situation requires. Real charisma, that joy in life and in others which cannot be faked, is a quality available to all healthy people, of every type.

P Perceiver

Perceiver vs. Judger is one of the most crucial factors in anyone s cognition, yet it s also one of the most commonly misunderstood. There are stereotypes and oversimplifications about all the letter pairs, causing people to be mistyped or made to feel that their own type is inferior in some way, and that doesn t help anyone. But unlike the other three letter pairs, the difference between Perceiver and Judger entirely changes a person s whole cognition process. The switching of just this one pair of letters produces a completely different order of cognition steps, resulting in nearly opposite strengths and weaknesses. A person who s mistyped between Perceiver and Judger might end up feeling confused about how their type thinks, what they excel at and what they need to watch out for, because the switching of these two letters changes around the entire cognition process.

As a Perceiver, you are not any less organized, responsible, or decisive, regardless of the plentiful oversimplifications on the matter. Perceivers simply prefer to take in options before committing to a course of action or opinion. Even if it takes longer in the short run to get something done, Perceivers prefer to get it done right. Some Perceivers may be messy or scatterbrained, and some may be incredibly finicky

or punctual, yet all Perceivers focus on taking in options

first, before deciding on a course to follow. They prefer to move forward cautiously, adapting carefully to any situation, rather than trying to plot a path and make it work.

Perceivers view the world and all experiences as potential tools that they can add to a growing arsenal of abilities. They approach life like an endless series of puzzles, instead of as a roadmap with definite, preplanned destinations. So in their drive to continually solve life s puzzles, Perceivers are constantly seeking better tools for the job. They re less focused on getting things done and checking them off, than

they are on learning how to get things done better in general. Frequently for a Perceiver, finishing a project or meeting a goal isn t even their real intent; they simply engage in experiences in order to learn something from them. Others may pressure them to finish what they begin, make a goal and stick to it, and go through life as a series of definite checklists, while in truth the Perceiver s mind is only seeking to test out new potential methods or tools. The project or goal isn t the objective; learning and testing new tools is. Once they find out how well their new tool or idea works, their mind is satisfied; they got what they were really after from the experience.

Therefore any attempt to force Perceivers to complete definite tasks will be difficult for them, because the completion of tasks wasn t really what they were seeking in the first place. They may be led to feel guilty for leaving piles of projects unfinished, but in truth their real goal was finished: the learning and testing of new tools. It is inefficient, and in fact irresponsible, to try to force Perceivers to finish projects when that would be a waste of their energy. Perceivers are most productive when they re allowed to see that productivity is measured not only by goals reached, but also by tools perfected. With a growing arsenal of better, faster tools,

Perceivers become more equipped to clear the way for others and show them better methods of completing projects and pursuing goals.

This is not to say that healthy Perceivers don t like to get

things done; it s simply not their primary focus. And likewise, healthy Judgers learn to enjoy considering new options and tools in their drive to plow forward, yet the perfecting of new tools isn t their main focus. The more Perceivers let themselves be Perceivers, the more they ll naturally find themselves getting things accomplished. The more they allow their minds to focus on exploring new methods and approaches, the more they won t be able to resist using those new and improved methods to knock out their goals in record speed! But if they feel guilted into suppressing their deep and necessary desire to find new tools, if they feel pressured into getting things done first, then their energy will be largely wasted and their minds will try to rebel against being forced to go forward using inferior tools.

At the same time, though, this focus on seeking better tools can sometimes make it hard for Perceivers to settle on a course of action and go forward with it. While Judgers may stride forward without considering sufficient alternatives, Perceivers may spend so much energy considering options that they fail to just take the leap and make a decision.

Watch out for this paralysis by analysis, focusing so much on potential solutions to a problem that you can t manage to even begin to choose one!

The ability to say, You know what? I have several options here that may work, and they re all too comparable to decide between them, so I ll just pick one and use it! is a powerful tool for Perceivers to add to their toolbox. Perceivers excel at adapting to new and changing situations, but there won t be anything new for them to adapt to unless they take a leap and see what happens! Considering the options, then taking a chance and adjusting after, allows Perceivers to be quick and decisive while still considering options and perfecting new tools. As always, the healthier we grow in any letter, the more we naturally and automatically gain the strengths of that letter and its opposite as well, while gradually losing the weaknesses of both.

IP Introverted Perceiver

The inward focus of Introversion, combined with Perceiving s focus on finding new options and tools, results in a unique proficiency for exploring possibilities within your own head. You naturally tend to enjoy imagining new ways that things could be done, new options that could be tried, and new questions that could be explored. This private mental laboratory of possibilities yields a great attention to the details of situations, aiming your internal thoughts at specific objects and moments in order to zero in and understand them. This lets you spot and remember details that others might forget, or not even notice in the first place.

In order to accurately imagine and explore possibilities in your mind, you constantly catalogue specific bits of information about the world. Whether it be a specific decorative pattern or a detailed schematic diagram, as an IP you have a natural eye for details, and may find yourself getting a kick out of just sitting back and remembering, analyzing, or reflecting on the specifics of situations. Your mind is always gathering points of data, the facts and details that create situations, and from those details you come to conclusions that might escape the notice of others.

This adeptness at drawing correct conclusions doesn t have to be overly technical, scientific, or brainy; most IPs just enjoy learning to be really good at whatever they love. By focusing on the details, IPs immerse themselves into athletics or mathematics, interior design or philosophical rhetoric, or anything at all that excites them. Introverted Perceivers tend to love specialization, focusing on one narrow slice of the world and devoting themselves to every detail of that slice in order to do it just right.

This can make some IPs feel a little sheepish, or even bitter toward others who diversify their interests rather than specializing, but remember that it s healthy, good, and necessary for IPs to specialize. The world needs specialists to zoom in, to spot the details that others might not, and to point out the conclusions that those details lead to. Don t let anyone make you feel strange or irresponsible for focusing on one narrow and deep corner of the universe; by digging deep, you can unearth treasures that benefit yourself and everyone around you.

The IP love of details comes out in everything, from loving specific, meaningful dates, to getting excited by math and computer code, from memorizing favorite lines of poetry to geeking out about a new technological toy or idea. Every detail, moment, and situation is special to IPs, who see com-

plexity and depth that others might not immediately understand. It s therefore remarkably common for IPs to love collecting things, specific things, that help them enjoy the details of moments and ideas.

Because of this focus on moments, situations, details, and specifics, it s only natural for IPs to assume that others view the world in the same way. Some IPs get very impatient with people who demonstrate less situational awareness of details, or less of a focus on drawing conclusions that seem obvious to them. Yet just as it s healthy for IPs to specialize, it can be equally healthy for people of other cognitive types to zoom out, or to zoom in on entirely different areas. And since IPs draw their understanding of people from the specific details and situations they ve noticed, they may fear that others will misjudge them based on isolated situations or details. A moment of anger, an embarrassing email, or a slight mistake in a project do not paint a complete picture of you as a person, and sensible people will know better than to judge you by such limited details.

In the same way, beware of judging the world and the universe by limited, situational details. What you observe to be true in one situation may be entirely false in another; the IP focus on details makes it very difficult to step back, zoom all the way out, and make universal statements about the way the world works. So be very careful with always/never statements, and with any kind of assertion about the way the world or people work generally. It s easy to fall into pessimistic pseudo-principles, making seemingly undeniable declarations about the pointlessness, meaninglessness, or arbitrariness of all sorts of things in life. Likewise, it s easy to cling to optimistic yet simplistic pseudo-principles that may not be universally true. In either case, remember that the details you observe in a situation, or even a series of situations, do not necessarily mean anything about the world as a whole.

Because your focus is on digging deep, finding new details and raising new questions, be careful about planting your feet in any opinion, habit, or attitude. Keep yourself free to continue exploring more and more options in your head! Allow yourself enough uncertainty that you ll keep questioning yourself, your beliefs, and everyone else s, so that you ll be free to notice new and exciting details, and raise compelling questions. And because you re so naturally zoomed in, let yourself enjoy branching out and taking in others observations as well. Seek out people you can use as sources of new ideas and observations to add onto your own, helping you see even more hidden wonders and possibilities.

Introverted Perceivers tend to have a unique eye for precision in every particular, especially when it comes to ideas or desires that fit into their chosen specialization. A lot of traits that are sometimes stereotypically assumed to be Thinker traits, such as thoroughness, meticulous attention to details, and a mind for numbers and data, are actually a result of Introverted Perception. And while Judgers are often falsely stereotyped as always being organized, the detail-oriented nature of IPs can lead them to be relentlessly perfectionist about the details of their specialized fields of interest. Exploring the possibilities of situations in their heads, IPs want everything they create and do to match up precisely with all the details they see in their mind s eye.

This may cause you to be overly critical of everything you produce, robbing you of the joy of the moments and objects you create. And if you re not careful, it can lead you to be overly critical of everyone else s creations as well, finding fault with everything you see, hear, eat, watch, read, and even with everyone you meet. This lack of appreciation can in fact eat away more and more at your own ability to create things the way you like them. Yet as you indulge yourself to take detail-oriented joy in all the beautiful little facets of everything, all the minute specifics that others might overlook, you ll grow more appreciative of the bits of things that do line up with your mind s Introverted Perceptions. In addition, as you let yourself take joy in the things that do go right, even very little things, you ll find that you grow more and more able to turn your mind s imaginings into perfect realities.

S Sensor

As a Sensor, you are not necessarily any more practical, more athletic, or more realistic than iNtuitives. Likewise, you don t have to be any less intelligent, bookish, rational, enlightened, or whatever else that oversimplified stereotypes may assert, both in books and online. Being a Sensor simply means that you see the world primarily in reference to your own experiences, while iNtuitives tend to view life in terms of concepts and ideas. Sensors consider all ideas and concepts in reference to their own gathered store of experience, rather than the other way around. Both are needed, and as with all the letters, everyone does both. Yet Sensors view everything in terms of their own experiences first and

foremost, before drawing conceptual ideas from those experiences.

This focus on actual experiences naturally results in seeing all the world as a great puzzle composed of separate, interlocking puzzle pieces. Every piece connects to its neighbors, and yet each exists as a distinct memory with its own meaning and applications. Sensors tend to focus on each individual piece of life, people, situations, and experiences, each in its own place, rather than focusing on the overall whole that they re part of. Everything is a distinct puzzle piece with its own place, and can be placed and understood independently of any other piece. This often causes Sensors to appear more concretely minded, as they focus on the distinct puzzle pieces of actual experiences.

However, just because Sensors thoughts and opinions tend to be more concrete, they are not necessarily any more accurate. Because they focus on the actual experiences that they ve lived, the implications and opinions that they draw from their experiences are heavily influenced by the context in which their experiences occurred. Sensors can often be the last ones to see just how much everything they believe might change drastically as soon as it is viewed through the lens of different experiences. Two different Sensors may have ironclad, perfectly rational convictions about opposing beliefs, each unable to see the world via the context of the other s entirely different experiences.

Yet a concerted and deliberate effort to work on understanding the underlying concepts behind their experiences, rather than simply focusing on the experiences alone, can help to gradually bring a Sensor s portion of the puzzle more and more in line with the rest of reality. It can be tempting for Sensors to try to shoehorn all concepts and ideas to conform to their own experiences, but as they instead humble their opinions to adapt to simple conceptual sense, they ll be able to see all their own experiences in every possible light.

They ll grow ever more able to easily understand the entirely different experiences of others, and more ready to see new experiences from a wider point of view without trying to force them to fit any preexisting set of beliefs.

Viewing everything in terms of actual experiences leads to an appreciation for all the good that has already been accomplished or accumulated both in one s own life, and in the world in general. This causes Sensors to frequently focus on

trying to maintain and protect all the good in things, people, and themselves as they already are. Unless someone stands up for the good in things, then precious opportunities, tools, and points of view may be lost, leaving everyone weaker by

the loss of insight and ability offered by things no one would stand up for. Yet Sensors must be especially careful not to end up seeking to protect everything unilaterally, or else they ll find themselves standing up for detrimental or even malicious things in the world or in themselves. It s good and necessary to try to keep the good in everything, but it is harmful to try to cling to unhealthy, false, or cruel attitudes or traditions simply because they re already there.

Sensors must also be careful not to fall into the trap of behaving as if the way things are now is the way they ve always been, and always will be. Such an attitude leads to defending all the bad parts of the current culture or situation alongside all the good. This is not to say that Sensors necessarily fear change; they may be perfectly happy with change, as long as it serves to better protect the good that already is. Healthy Sensors may in fact seek out change for just this purpose: to do away with harmful things in order to safeguard beneficial ones. Their focus on experiences gives them a keen awareness of things as they are currently, but also makes it harder for them to be sure where things might end up in the future.
As always, both Sensing and iNtuition are needed, and both can be equally healthy or unhealthy. Healthy Sensors should seek to see things through interconnected concepts and not just through the lens of experience, yet they should also allow their main focus to be on the individual, experiential puzzle pieces of life. As they seek to see the world through concepts as well as experience, they ll grow more able to see all the varied possibilities of things as they could be, which will only serve to help them maintain and enjoy the good in things as they already are. While numerous stereotypes portray Sensing as less academic, idealistic, or enlightened, all types can be intelligent or unintelligent, idealistic or pessimistic, each in their own unique ways.

Indeed, any attempt to live by experience without idealism is

simply unhealthy and limiting. Such close-mindedness tends to come from disregarding all the varied experiences had by others besides oneself, even disregarding one s own experiences if they don t fit the mold of current attitudes. Healthier Sensing lives by more experience, not less, and therefore grows ever more idealistic and ever more practical in its enjoyment of everything. The more a Sensor lets themselves be a Sensor, the more enlightened, hopeful, and farseeing they ll become in all their daily experiences.

T Thinker

As a Thinker, you are not necessarily any more rational, heartless, bitter, or whatever else the numerous stereotypes may say about Thinking. Being a Thinker simply means that you focus first on the use of things, before considering their intrinsic meaning. Everyone looks at both use and meaning, but Thinkers focus first and foremost on all the varied uses for ideas, possibilities, and people.

This means that Thinkers want things, people, events, and the whole world to live up to the abilities that they see in them. Any person or thing that doesn t live up to its potential abilities is failing in its possible use, which will naturally be especially disappointing to a Thinker. Yet all this focus on use and ability gives Thinkers a zoomed-in sort of attention to the importance of each part of the whole, seeing how each piece is necessary and even precious in its own place. Usefulness thus has a meaning and a significance all its own. Any healthy Thinker will learn to care for the intrinsic preciousness of things in the wider perspective of meaning, but their natural focus will still be on the necessities of use foremost. This results in a direct ability to understand the steps needed to attain any goal, focusing on the benefit or detriment of each possible step. This ties use back to the wider picture of meaning, as use turns out to be meaning approached through the steps necessary to get there.

It is this focus on the steps needed to accomplish things that gives Thinkers a keen awareness of the potential benefits or detriments of any action, idea, or attitude. Beneficial things are of more use to the furthering of hopes and plans, while

detrimental events or actions directly detract from usefulness. Thinkers therefore tend to find themselves focused more on the sequence of tasks between them and their goal, which helps them move forward one step at a time instead of staring with idle hope at the long road ahead. It is this attention to the sequence of each step that gives Thinkers a unique appreciation for meaning, seeing the preciousness of each brush stroke in the picture, without which Feelers might end up neglecting some of the most meaningful, yet least obvious things.

The differences between Thinkers and Feelers have garnered a particularly large amount of stereotypes, many of which seem flat-out mean spirited. Thinkers are no less emotional than Feelers, and Feelers are no less rational than Thinkers; everyone, of every type, can and should be both healthily emotional and rational. And every cognitive type is equally prone to being overemotional, each in unique ways. The difference doesn t lie between Thinkers and Feelers, but rather, between being healthy or unhealthy in general. An overly emotion-driven psyche is an unhealthy one, and every type is equally vulnerable to being hijacked by their own emotions in times of stress or weakness, each in their different ways.

Now, Thinkers focus on sequential, useful steps can sometimes appear to simulate a greater focus on reason than on emotion. A focus on the specific uses of things can elicit immediate, private emotions like enjoyment or frustration, excitement or disappointment, and such ubiquitous yet personal emotions are often overlooked when people think themselves coldly rational. While Feelers focus on the meaning of things in the context of the whole picture can generate great feelings of hope or despair, wonder or contempt, such open and noticeable emotions are of no more or less hindrance to reason than Thinkers quieter moods.

Thinkers are no less emotional than Feelers, and no less vulnerable or tender in any way. Thinkers emotions focus more on specific uses or misuses of things, and Feelers emotions are most often applied to the whole picture; apart from that, both can enjoy equal connection with emotion, as well as equal risk of overemotional irrationality.

And no healthy person, of any type, should indulge in irrationality or emotional subjectivity. While some stereotypes imply that only Thinkers are objective in their views, both Thinkers and Feelers can and should strive to understand the objective, measurable nature of things. Just as healthy Thinkers focus on the objective use of things in their own

right, so also healthy Feelers focus on the objective, measurable significance of things in the context of everything else.

Subjectivity, reaction, and impulsive emotion are neither a Feeler trait nor a Thinker trait; they re simply human, and all types are equally equipped to master them healthily, in their own ways.

In the same manner, all types can learn to be in touch with their emotions and all the power therein, each in their own specialized way. To be human is to have emotions, and that s good! Healthy, bridled emotions provide vital perspective that human thought alone cannot hope to contain.

Healthy emotion reminds us of truths we might be entirely unaware of, even as we feel that they re there. This is why emotion can be such a powerful, guiding light, at times dwarfing conscious reason. Yet this is also why runaway emotions are so dangerous, smothering all attempts at reason and balanced perspective, just as all powerful things are dangerous when they run amok.

This sheer power of emotions, and their ability to remind us of things our thoughts alone cannot keep track of, is why suppressed emotions always find a way to influence all our thoughts, views, and actions. This makes suppressed emotions much more dangerous, because their sweeping influence is ignored even while they steer conscious thought.

The quickest way to be controlled by emotion is to pretend it isn t a factor, thereby letting it run unattended in the back of our minds, coloring all experiences and skewing all opinions and ideas. Only unhealthy people, whether Thinkers or Feelers, attempt to suppress emotion, or indulge in being driven by it.

Regardless of how unemotional some may seem, those who are the most quiet about their emotions are often the ones who nurture them the most deeply, whether they mean to or not. Being a Thinker therefore does not mean you re doomed to be cold, mean, or unfriendly in any way, nor does it justify such unhealthy coping mechanisms. While some may attempt to be coldly unemotional, that desire is often a very emotional desire in and of itself, usually resulting from fear, loneliness, or pride.

Such attempts to be unemotional are an example of unhealthiness. While blubbery, stereotypical emotions can certainly get in the way of reason, so also can emotions like distaste, discomfort at unwelcome ideas, and disdain or pessimism block all rational thought. These sorts of negative emotions are still emotions, yet they often replace reason for those who consider themselves unemotional.

Yet when reason and emotion are nurtured together in their natural relationship, we can live safely above either extreme of overemotional subjectivity, or falsely emotionless hardness. We can cultivate a rational and honest approach to life by remembering that emotions, when heeded, will lead to new discoveries and protect from unseen hazards. Feelings of all kinds can help us prioritize where we should employ our thoughts and our energy. Without emotion, logic loses context and perspective, causing it to neglect key principles and wander into inaccuracy. Healthy emotion is free to all types, both Thinkers and Feelers, each in their different ways.

ST Sensing Thinker

With Sensing viewing life as a series of distinct puzzle pieces, Sensing Thinkers naturally focus on the usefulness of the puzzle piece they care about most. They seek to understand the things they care about as they already are, in order to get the most effective use out of themselves, others, and the world. STs are all about creating and protecting an environment where the things they love can flourish in the use they already have. This is how STs find and enjoy the intrinsic worth of everything, by experiencing things in the most useful, beneficial ways.

This focus on the beneficial uses of experiences tends to cause STs to look to the past, in order to learn from past experience how to do better next time. This is where they gather most of their information to make choices and form opinions. Sensing Thinkers are therefore very protective of the past experiences of whatever they care about most: Some are most protective of their own past choices, while others are quick to defend the past of their chosen cause or ideology, and still others revere history itself as a trove of useful experiences to learn from. In any case, STs want the past of whatever they care about most to be as useful as possible, and may resent any implication to the contrary.

With ST s focus on the useful lessons to be derived from past experiences, Sensing Thinkers tend to think of people, actions, and everything in terms of right ways and wrong ways. Even if they fear that they themselves often do things in a wrong way, they will naturally view themselves and others as being frankly correct or incorrect in their methods. The right way is the most useful way, and the past illustrates right ways and wrong ways to do anything. Often without realizing it, STs think of moral right and wrong in these terms. Doing something the wrong way seems like a mark of foolishness, immaturity, or outright stupidity, while doing things right seems to display moral uprightness, honor, and intelligence. Sensing Thinkers excel in learning how to find and perfect the most useful methods for whatever they focus on, yet they should be careful to remember that there are many other facets of right and wrong besides right ways and wrong ways. As always, learning from the strengths of other cognitive types leads to the greatest usefulness of your own.

Cognition Steps ISTP

Now, we can combine all your letters to find your full cognitive specialty: ISTP! By combining the four Scopes IP, IJ, EP, and EJ with the four Objectives ST, SF, NT, and NF we derive the sixteen different facets of cognition, each with its own unique strengths and specializations, which all the other types depend on. And each comes with its own particular weaknesses as well, needing the support of other types who are strong in those areas. Only with all sixteen types combined can we enjoy and benefit from the entire spectrum of zoomed in and zoomed out perspectives, collective and individual focuses, usefulness and meaning, things as they are and things as they can yet become. A deeper understanding of each type leads to better use and appreciation for all types of cognition.

As an ISTP, your entire cognition revolves around your unique combination of these cognitive variables: the IP Scope focusing on the details of situations, and the ST Objective seeking the use of things as they already are. This unique combination prompts every thought, motivates every action, counsels every judgment and inspires every worldview. It sums up the end goal of everything you pursue, the result of the things that matter the most to you in your most private heart.

Every time you re faced with any decision, any thought or feeling, any experience or person or anything, your mind naturally races through four cognitive steps. The order of these cognitive steps depends on your unique Scope and Objective, as you subconsciously focus first on the things that matter the most to you. You re probably so used to thinking in your own order, all the time, that it may seem like the only natural way to think. This makes it all the more amazing that people of differing cognition approach the same world so differently, each offering something unique and powerful to share.

As an ISTP, your first cognition step is to examine the specific details of a situation, because that s what matters most to you! You turn inward to consider situational details in your mind, in order to draw conclusions about their usefulness (Ti, or introverted Thinking).

Secondly, you take that meaningful Data and use it to look outward, comparing it with what you Observe of the motives, desires, and character of people (Se, or extraverted Sensing).
Thirdly, you turn inward to make conceptual connections based on who you ve decided to trust as sources of information, in order to decide on Action and form opinions (Ni, or introverted iNtuition).
Fourthly and finally, you watch the results of your Actions and opinions in order to better understand the workings of the world and the universe as a whole.
You form an overall worldview based on Principles you ve deduced by looking outward and seeing what seems most meaningful, precious, and significant in life (Fe, or extraverted Feeling).

And then the cycle starts over: Your understanding of principles illuminates new details, whose profound implications of meaning give you more to mull over (Fi, or introverted

Feeling), your fourth step feeding back into your first, over and over. You may go through this entire cycle of cognition many times in a single second without even noticing.

Universal Principles are your fourth and final cognition step because they re what you focus on the least. This makes Principles the weakest of your cognitive steps. As you focus on all the numberless details of each situation, it can be mind-boggling to try to zoom out and find the universal rules that apply without exception to every situation of every

kind, ever. And when you try, it s hard not to end up with oversimplified generalities that don t really apply in many situations. This is nothing to be embarrassed about. Every type has a weakness, just as every type has a strength that may appear almost superhuman to other types.

Healthy IPs are naturally able to delve deep into probing questions that others might never even think to ask. Healthy IJs, on the flip side, can provide complex and comprehensive answers to even the most baffling of those questions. EPs see right to the core of people with speed and surety that might seem reckless to others, while EJs accomplish long lists of tasks with precision while other types would struggle to even get started. All the types need each other; this is why we call them the Type Heroes! Each approaches the same world from such a different angle, and each supports, guides, and teaches every other. By seeking out and learning from other types, especially types that think very differently from you, you can grow stronger in all your cognition steps.

And usually the best way to grow more reliable and strong in all your cognitive steps is to focus on your first step. This is the step that your mind naturally prioritizes first anyway; it s what you care about the most, even when you might feel like you shouldn t. As you focus on paying attention to your first step, you ll find that all your other cognitive steps grow

sharper and stronger as a result, almost automatically. When it comes to cognition, play to your strengths and your

weaknesses will grow to keep up.

It s when people focus too much on trying to improve their fourth step directly that they tend to become defensive, depressed, and discouraged about it, often neglecting their strengths and falling into denial that they even have a weakness. Some such people try to cover their weakness by inadvertently posing as a different cognitive type, in order to act like others who don t share their weak area. Yet this usually results in only a parody of the type they re trying to become, attempting to gain the strengths of another type without first mastering their own.

You can develop all the strengths of all the types, but you cannot do it by trying to fight or suppress what you naturally want most. Let your first cognitive step be your focus, let yourself be you, and then you ll be free to grow to become everything you want to become.

Focus on your strength of seeing and understanding the details of situations; as you do, your weakness in comprehending universal principles will grow stronger of its own accord.

And remember, if an attempted principle turns out to be a flawed generality, then that just gives you more data to work with! Beware of getting down on yourself about principles and worldview; enjoy getting the most use out of every detail in every situation, and then you ll learn how to be a better force for zeroing in and accomplishing everything that matters to you.

## Type Specialization ISTP Weapons Specialist

Cognition is the result of where you naturally focus your attention, your desires, and your interests. Regardless of what your momentary desires or interests may be, each of us has certain deep, secret hopes that mean more to us than anything. While moods and opinions may change, these deepest desires are such a pure reflection of who we really are. In a world where there is so much to do, so much to experience, so much need and so many discoveries waiting to be found, we each inadvertently focus the most on some things over others. The things that we focus on most of all reflect what we want most out of life, deep down. This comes out through cognition, as the unique specialization of your cognitive type.

As the ISTP Weapons Specialist, perhaps nothing is more important to you than getting the best use out of every detail

in each moment. Cognitively, you focus on the use (T) of details and situations (IP) as they already are (S). This causes you to think of everything in terms of how it applies to theoretical people, to the lives of the human race overall. What matters most to you, deep down, is doing the absolute best you can at what you do, when you re doing it.

This causes Weapons Specialists to specialize, choosing a few related disciplines that they pour their whole selves into. By becoming a true master of their weapon of choice, whether that weapon be clever banter, technical expertise, or any other useful skill, they can be sure to always be prepared to make the best use of every situation. Rather than trying to be a moderate jack of all trades with diverse interests, ISTPs get a thrill out of excelling beyond excellence in their chosen passion and everything closely related to it.
They love to push themselves to the limits of what s possible in a situation, armed with sufficient skill to question and explore what can be done in any immediate moment. The sense of security offered by such aptitude allows Weapons Specialists to relax into accustomed snark or outright silliness, as long as they feel that their specialized skill is needed and wanted. As an ISTP Weapons Specialist, you find the most use in straightforward application of your skills, insights, and experiences, applied here and now as each situation demands.

None of this means that your specialization of such surpassing, zoomed-in mastery comes easy for you. You have to work at it, just as much as anyone else would. The difference between you and other types is that you care to work at this, above all else. Some may say that it s just easier for you to be so good at what you do, but that s not true; you simply care enough about finding how to put your skills to the best use, that you re willing to work much harder at it.
No cognitive type has it easy; every type has to work just as hard at their specialization as anyone else would have to.
And every type has to deal with social pressure that tries to make them feel ashamed or embarrassed of their unique specialization. This pressure results in unhappiness and deep, internal conflict, as people feel tempted to ignore their specialization in an effort to not stand out, rock the boat, or look foolish or make anyone else uncomfortable. When we try to ignore our own deepest desires, the reflection of who we really are and really can be, we feel torn, frustrated, and unfulfilled.
This is why understanding our own cognition is so important! As we come to understand what we already wanted in the first place, we learn how to get out of our own way.

We learn to let ourselves shine, rather than hiding our light.

The world needs what each of us can uniquely offer. We need all the strengths of all the types; each is special at the same time, because each is special in a different way. You don t do anyone any good when you hide your unique strength, even if you re afraid it will make others feel uncomfortable. Let yourself be the Weapons Specialist you are, be proud and snarkily flaunt your sharp expertise, and do it in your own personal way. As you do, you ll implicitly give others permission to excel in their own chosen disciplines, all while giving them greater appreciation for the work you ve put into yours.

Type Angst ISTP Snape Superiority

Everyone has good days and bad days; every type enjoys successes and suffers through failures. Yet we each react to those same successes and failures differently, depending on our cognition. The things we value most, and the things we focus on most, determine how we subconsciously interpret everything that happens to us. While our Type Specialization reflects what we most desire out of life, every cognitive type also has a Type Angst, a reaction to our deepest fears, worries, and insecurities.

Of course, anyone can be afraid of anything. And anyone, of any type, can suffer from any weakness. In fact, it s much easier to gain the unique weaknesses of other types than it is to gain their unique strengths! When we attempt to adopt the strengths of another type before mastering our own, usually all we end up with is the weaknesses of both and the strengths of neither. Yet each cognitive type has one deepest, most fundamental worry, resulting from their unique order of cognition steps.

As an ISTP Weapons Specialist, your central fear, beneath all others, is that you are an outsider, never really part of the group of normal people. Your experiences are your own, and so you worry that you cannot ever really identify with

everyone else. Again, anyone can have this fear. But for Weapons Specialists, this worry is at the root of them all.

With ISTPs weakest cognition step being Principles via Feeling, Weapons Specialists naturally fear that their understanding of the trends of the world at large is especially lacking. Specifically, they worry that their understanding of universal principles lacks meaningful insights (F) in an experiential way (S). You fear that your understanding of the way
the world works in practice is too cold and mundane. This
unconscious worry that your worldview is not SF enough results in the fear that you won t be good company for anyone
else. You may be good at what you do, very good even, but
when it comes to being a friend and bringing a smile to others faces, you feel out of step, separate, and too cold or utilitarian. You want to be a friend, you want to be able to have
fun with everyone else, but you fear that in reality you only
hurt people, let them down, or even scare them.
This is almost certainly false, but that doesn t make the fear
any less persistent.
Since these worries come from our cognition, we might not
even realize that not everyone has them, just as we sometimes forget that not everyone has our same Type Specialization. And since these fears come from our cognition, they ve

been with each of us for as long as we ve been thinking.
They can be overcome, entirely, but only by understanding
how they work. Yet when each of us is young, we inadvertently react to every scare or disappointment through the
lens of our own type s central fear. The things that leave the
deepest scars are the ones that hit us right in this most vulnerable place.
But since our minds therefore associate these fears with the
earliest experiences of childhood, we ironically tend to run
to these fears as if they were a place of safety. Childhood
usually feels warm, safe, and right in our minds, even if in
reality it was nothing of the sort. So when life gets hard,
when disappointment strikes, whenever we feel insecure,
overwhelmed, or uncomfortable at all, our minds naturally
and inadvertently rush back to these deeply ingrained childhood fears. The coping behaviors that result are our unique Type Angsts.
As a Weapons Specialist, whenever you feel or experience
anything stressful or negative in any way, your mind tries to
rush back to the supposed safety of childhood. This causes a
surge of your central fear that you are too hard and strange
to really ever fit in with everyone else. As a result, you then
feel the tempting pull to indulge in ISTP Snape Superiority.

Snape Superiority is the assertion that the reason you re not
part of the group is because your unique experiences make

you better than them. Wiser, cleverer, more practical, even more social; in whatever way you justify it, Snape Superiority tells you that others just aren t up to your high standards. This leads to the attitude that your experiences and knowhow are more important than your relationships with others. That you don t need to have friends, and you certainly don t need to be concerned with being liked; your superior knowledge, skill, and experience are far more useful.

As an ISTP, you naturally focus on getting the most use (T) out of all the details of every situation (IP) you ve ever experienced in your past (S). This means that your own experiences are and should be among the most important and personal things for you, as some of your most powerful tools.

Yet Snape Superiority becomes a problem when it causes you to act as if you ve experienced more than everyone else, implying that others experiences are shallow, common, or nonexistent. It can make you uncomfortable when you meet someone who s experienced things that you are entirely unfamiliar with, and might lead you to imply that you still outexperience them, even when you know almost nothing about their area of expertise.

Likewise, Snape Superiority can tempt you to act as if your personal area of expertise is the best, most useful, most practical or even the most meaningful, and that anyone without sufficient skill at it must be stupid, lazy, or worthless. There is nothing wrong with you specializing; specialization is your unique Type Specialization! But beware of oversimplifying the wide complexity of the world by implying that everyone must specialize, or even that they must specialize in what you specialize in.

With your weakest cognition step being universal Principles, you may have trouble fully realizing just how diverse the world is, how enormous and complex a machine it is, needing so many different outlooks and specialties. You may have trouble really seeing how others very different experiences and skills can add to yours. Snape Superiority robs you of others perspective, insights, and also their friendship and assistance, which makes life unnecessarily harder. It causes Weapons Specialists to sabotage their own treasured specialization, getting less and less use out of each situation because they re too busy ignoring others insights and declaring their own superiority.

Particularly unhealthy ISTPs expend so much effort trying to prove their own superiority by competing, arguing, and showboating, that they end up wasting their lives rather than actually applying their experiences. This waste causes them to compensate by acting as if they ve experienced a little of every possible type of experience, that they ve seen it

all and done it all, and that anything outside their knowledge must be worthless, stupid, or fake. None of this ever helps the ISTP feel any better about themselves for more than a moment, and then they feel only more separate and alone after the high of rivalry passes. An unhealthy ISTP s entire reason for being becomes proving that they re the best at everything, in direct opposition to their Type Specialization. This ultimate contradiction, desperately fighting against one s own deepest, most treasured desire, is miserable to say the least.

Yet even healthy Weapons Specialists tend to indulge in Snape Superiority when things get hard. As a natural and unintentional way of guarding themselves, a Weapons Specialist may look down on knowledge or skills outside their own, as if enjoying their own specialization requires refusing to learn from anything or anyone else. These unintentional slips into ISTP s Type Angst are nothing to beat yourself up about; after all, they re unintentional. And you don t need to feel uncomfortable at all about things you re unfamiliar with. The overwhelmingly diverse complexity of the world means that there s always a new adventure waiting for you, always a new way for you to put your skills, knowledge, and experience to the test!

All types can be tempted to declare that they or their loved ones are already everything they d like to be, even if it means ignoring glaring truths or putting others down. Our Type Angsts tempt us to feel entitled, like we deserve to already be at our goal, rather than being willing to learn and grow patiently, gaining successes for real. This sense of entitlement is a harmful twisting of the good desire to be special. In reality, everyone can be equally special in ways that are different from one another, allowing all to be unique in unique, diverse ways.

As you surround yourself with the loving support of people who care, as you seek out others who try to understand you and accept you, you can grow less and less vulnerable to the self-sabotage of Snape Superiority. Look to your Type Specialization, be a Weapons Specialist with a vengeance, and your mind will retreat less and less into the fears and scars that result in your Type Angst. And even when no one else is

around, perhaps the best, most effective, and most fulfilling way to gradually eliminate your Type Angst for good, is to get in touch with your Paradoxitype.

ISTP Paradoxitype ESFJ Cavalry

Each cognitive type enjoys a special relationship with every other. Types with opposite letters can form a special, exciting bond with each other, while types with opposite first and last letters have a unique sense of camaraderie and closeness. Each relationship between the many types has special qualities and advantages, but maybe the most important of all these is Paradoxitype.

Your Paradoxitype is the secret person you are deep down. It is not your true self, but rather the hidden, private side of yourself that others may rarely get to see. It can shine out when you re feeling especially exuberant or comfortable among close friends, who get to see this hidden you that others might never know. On the flip side, in times of great distress you may be unable to keep it in, leaving it to burst out of you haphazardly. Yet the more you get in touch with and cultivate your Paradoxitype, the more easily and naturally you ll end up mastering the strengths of your own type, while avoiding its weaknesses.

Cognitively, Paradoxitypes differ in all their letters except S or N. So for you as an ISTP Weapons Specialist, your secret, inner Paradoxitype is the ESFJ Cavalry! This may seem, well, paradoxical to stereotypical ISTP attitudes, but that s exactly what makes it so special. It s this sort of complexity that makes healthy people POP! It s this adorable paradox within you that can always surprise people just when they think they ve got you figured.

Learn to let loose your inner Cavalry. Focus on creating joyful experiences for those you love. Ride high at the head of your group of friends and loved ones, showing them how to have a good time and be genuinely happy. Caring intensely for the needs and feelings of people close to you, give them comfort and safety, and make them laugh! And in every little

thing you do, do it with style! The more you let your inner Cavalry come out in all you do, the more you ll naturally stand tall as a mighty Weapons Specialist in unprecedented strength, complexity, compassion, and genuine happiness.

Obviously, understanding your own cognition is a marvelous tool. We each approach life according to the particular Scope and Objective of our unique Type Specialization, so it s immeasurably empowering to know how that works. The more we understand what our mind is already trying to do, the better we can gain what we ve always been after, the more we can avoid the pitfalls that have always nagged us, and the more fully ourselves we can always be.

In this culture where some make flippant declarations about human nature being unavoidably corrupt, jealous, or selfdestructive, it s powerful to understand how our minds really work. We don t have to feel at the mercy of Type Angsts or other weaknesses, when we know where they come from and how to heal them. We don t have to repeatedly feel like the person we see in the mirror isn t quite up to the caliber of the person we d like to be in our secret hearts. We don t have to constantly struggle for elusive fulfillment, success, and lasting joy, when we learn how to get out of our own way in pursuit of what we ve always really wanted all along.

We can each be a unique, one-of-a-kind version of our own cognition s Type Hero. These days, most people roll their eyes at the idea of real heroism. It s just not realistic, not practical. We re so often trapped in occupying ourselves with the gray repetition of maintaining the things we care about, and so optimism bows the knee to routine. Hope struggles against the harsh verdicts of experience.

But when your car won t start, you can throw up your hands in surrender and accept that maybe it was never meant to run in the first place, or you can learn how it works and find out how to fix the problem. When life doesn t match up with what we really feel it can and should be, we can declare that it was never meant to be that great anyway, or we can learn how it works and find out how to fix the problems. You are far more complex than any car, yet maybe the simplistic, eager dreams of childhood weren t so far off. Maybe as you learn to tune your own cognitive engine, you can slowly grow to attain everything your deepest desires have always

reached for.
You can be a hero, and this world certainly needs heroes.
But what does a real-life hero look like? Real heroes are

usually not flashy, not famous, and certainly heroes aren t
afraid to work tirelessly to do what needs to be done while
receiving little or no recognition. It s quite common in fact
for heroes to be resented for enduring hardship and sacrifice
in order to lift others. Heroes are willing to go through
whatever is necessary in order to help those who need it,
and as they let themselves go through pain, humiliation, and
hopelessness, they gradually grow to shine as larger-thanlife, apparently superhuman figures in the real world who
inspire others to reach for their own heroic possibilities.
Now, there are plenty of people who work very hard to excel
at physical or mental pursuits, yet who are rather selfserving. That s not heroic. Heroism is not about having superhuman abilities; it s about learning how to do superhuman good with the abilities you have.
You do not need to wait to have greater abilities than you already have in order to be heroic. Heroes are those who use
their own abilities to selflessly help others, in whatever ways
they can. As we start with the desire to help, using the abilities we have, then our abilities naturally increase. As we
humbly help in little ways, we grow more prepared and able
to see how the world needs our unique, personal strengths
in larger ways.

Stand tall as you, as the Weapons Specialist you are, with
your own style, your own experiences and insights and particular skills. Just be you, and learn how to get out of your
own way. You can be a hero. You can dive in with superhuman expertise, doing things for others that they could never
imagine doing themselves! The more you grow into the full
measure of the ISTP Weapons Specialist you ve already always been, the more successful, fulfilling, and irrevocably
happy you can become, because it will just be who you are.